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Writing 50: Critical Reading and Rhetoric

1 May 2026

Antiviral: How a Bio-Capitalism Film Warns Against Dehumanization In Our Modern World

Imagine a world where you can get injected with the same type of virus that infects your favorite celebrity, enjoy meat reproduced by their original cells, and even own a copyright of their biological product after they die. This isn't just a horrifying, imaginative story, but an exaggerated version of our commodified world. The film *Antiviral* depicts a world in which these services can be easily purchased by the public, converting intimate connections into a highly structured industrial market chain. The story begins with the main character, Syd, who works on collecting and selling celebrity viruses for the Lucas Clinic. Going down to the black market, he transmits the viruses into his own body as a way to smuggle out its copyright. After accidentally injecting a deadly virus from the superstar Hannah Giest, he discovers that it was genetically modified by a competitor company from a previous virus. In order to save his own life, Syd proposes the idea of building an "afterlife" product with Hannah's death. By turning the celebrity's corpse into raw materials of cell culture, Syd contributes to the exacerbation of bio-capitalism, and eventually transitions from an exploited victim to an assistant of crime (Cronenberg). Identifying *Antiviral* as a bio-capitalism film, we will discuss how the combination of film elements demonstrates the role of commodification in eroding humanity, and how this phenomenon is deeply connected to today's world.

As the key concept of bio-capitalism film, bio-capitalism is a phenomenon that occurs when biological components, processes, or genetic information are treated as a commodity and used for profit maximization. With the rise of new bio-med technologies, it has become a term that we encounter more and more frequently in real-life situations, including the celebrity economy. From make-up products to cosmetic surgeries, the way people pursue “celebrity-loved” products has only become more extreme, driven by a strong will for fame and perfection. The fact that bio-capitalism diminishes individual differences and encourages identical products at a measurable price has brought many concerns. For example, Kaushik Sunder Rajan, the author of *Biocapital: The Constitution of Postgenomic Life*, has commented in his book that it ties the concept of “life itself” into an enterprise setting, which implies “reconfigurations in subjectivity” and even “a different grammar of life” (Rajan, 178). This creates a strong argument suggesting that the overuse of capitalism on life itself could lead to dehumanization.

The film *Antiviral* also demonstrates a strong approach in criticizing the role of bio-capitalism in diminishing human nature under a medical horror setting. Compared to those traditional horror stories, which often involve supernatural elements indicating their context belongs to a purely imaginative world, *Antiviral* serves more like a magnifier that reflects these realistic issues happening in our everyday life and their disastrous effects. Featuring a futuristic depiction of our contemporary world, the film provides an extreme example of commodification, an act that erases all human qualities from a person and evaluates them based on a numeric price. Through the use of film elements, power dynamic twists, and normalized horror elements, the film depicts a society where betrayal wins over the fake intimacy established by money, warning audiences that we aren’t just consuming the celebrities but also consuming our own emotions, empathy, and rationality.

The concept of dehumanization is shown in a combination of film elements, including sound, color, and motion, creating a sense of emotional suppression. Unlike traditional films, which often include a theme music highlighting characters' emotions, *Antiviral* replaces the background music with a long-lasting, eerie sound. While it does create a creepy feeling, its consistent soundscape, slow rhythm, and long duration actually remind viewers of traits from the meditation music, showing it's actually trying to calm down the tension instead of raising a sudden jump scare. The whispering sound from the dialogue in the film is also unconventional, which hardly involves any expression of personal feelings but is mostly based on facts and actions.

In addition to the exceptionally quiet sound, the film also adopts unique visualized elements, such as monotonous color and slow motion. Color components in this film are limited to black and white, as well as sets of colors from the Morandi color system, which refers to low-saturated colors with a gray tone (Cheng, 50). Combined with the actor's slow movements, it creates a sense of dullness and tedium that insulates audiences from emotion. While most visual elements follow this pattern, the only times where the film shows high saturation of motion and color are limited to two circumstances: Hannah's red lip on posters and screens, and Syd crawling in blood to escape being arrested by the competitive firm (Cronenberg 01:26:50; Cronenberg 01:33:16). The former one, which represents a perfect projection of Hannah instead of her pale appearance in real life, shows that people's impression of celebrities comes from intentional branding made by capitalists, which often covers up who they are as a real person. Meanwhile, the scene related to Syd's anger represents the rebellion of a normal citizen fighting against the darkness of capitalism. The fact that he was being pushed down towards the floor and couldn't speak a word demonstrates censorship under bio-capitalism, suggesting that individuals' effort is vulnerable in front of this systematic injustice.

What is more important about the film is who contributes to bio-capitalism. The film establishes the point through its unconventional power dynamics, which usually involve a central authority exploiting the rest of the public. In *Antiviral*, this hierarchy structure is designed with an interesting twist, implying that the truth is often not what it looks like on the surface. At the beginning of the film, Hannah Geist's large image and her products almost occupy every scene, as if her existence were the "big brother" that controls people's zealous pursuit of celebrities. After being caught by the deadly virus, we can see a dramatic shift in people's attitudes. The public, which is represented by the press's perspective, has gone viral to spread the news topic; the capitalist, which is the virus company, has designed the murder to declare ownership of Hannah's afterlife product; the victims, represented by Syd's current situation, eventually join the party of capitalists for their own sake; even Hannah's closest people, her doctor and care provider, betray her for their own benefit (Cronenberg 01:38:25). This sudden plot twist reveals that underneath Hannah's heroic image, she is actually a puppet manipulated by society's bio-capitalism. This massive betrayal shows that the market power has never been controlled by Hannah herself, but instead contributed by the greediness of every single person within this systematic paradox.

Horror elements, especially the ones that are being normalized as part of the society feature, are used to highlight the ongoing transition of dehumanization in real-life projection. For example, the fact that restaurants begin serving celebrities' meat as part of the dining service suggests an extreme commercialization of human organs, which crosses over the moral convention. The fact that consumers are willing to pay for a celebrity's virus and inject to their own body features a severe mental abnormality, as people normally wouldn't hurt themselves. In a world where social norms and moral values are strongly distorted, characters who have been living under this weird situation unconsciously mean more than usual. They create lively examples of how capitalism has changed the way people think about others,

from real humans to commodities, through a process that could hardly be recognized. The characters themselves also go through changes from holding some kind of compassion to entering a completely monstrous state. The ending scene of the film captures Syd sucking blood that seeped out of Hannah's body tissue, marking his transition from a victim to an indifferent killer (Cronenberg 01:42:56). His performance is considered "a considerable feat of agonized acting" and "fits of hallucinatory delirium" (Holden), providing a daunting example of dehumanization driven by bio-capitalism. The horror elements of both individuals and society are not obvious at first glance. Rather, they all feature humans' normal behavior under an abnormal context, warning audiences that the subtle influence caused by bio-capitalism is usually invisible.

In a world where bio-capitalism has become more prevalent due to technological advancement, the horror elements in the film no longer seem far away. From the most basic visual and audio elements, power dynamic twists, to the more complicated use of normalized horror, *Antiviral* has constructed a world that seems more like a futuristic prediction rather than pure science fiction. Under its depiction, the horrible consequences of bio-capitalism, especially the degradation of humanity, no longer feel far away. Instead, it quickly seeps into our lives until it becomes part of our lives, through a process that could hardly be noticed. When we lose our sympathy toward other people's misfortune, when we evaluate human intimacy with a set of values, and when we consume these products without questioning what exploitation we might have brought to others, what will our world look like? The film ends with the tragedy of Hannah's death and the death of our precious human characteristics. But outside the frame, it proposes a difficult question that still requires an answer from the audience: Are we completely accelerating towards a world of capitalism, or can we still protect our qualities as humans?

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